



GULVEER ON THE RISE

Giant strides: Gulveer Singh broke Avinash Sable's national record in the 5,000m, clocking a time of 13:18.92 at the Portland Track Festival last year.

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Should he meet his goal of **cracking the 27min** barrier this season, Gulveer Singh has even loftier targets for 2026 and beyond, leading up to the 2028 Olympics. But there are sacrifices on the way.

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Amongst the various familial obligations that Gulveer Singh had to fulfil when he returned home to his village of Sirsa in western Uttar Pradesh's Atrauli district early in December, there was one that meant a lot to him personally. He drove his new tractor — the one he had bought using part of the prize money he received for winning a bronze in the 10,000m at last year's Asian Games — down to the town of Atrauli. There, he got a custom decal fitted on the bonnet of the machine.

'Pari,' it reads now.

The name is special to him. It's that of his daughter, born just a few days earlier.

The 23-year-old wasn't at home for the birth of his first-born child on the 23rd of November this year. He was in Hachioji, Japan. There, running the 10,000m on a chilly evening at Kamiyugi Park Athletics Stadium during the Hachioji Long Distance Championships, Gulveer pulled away from the chasing group to finish in first place with a

time of 27:14.88.

In doing so, he erased his own national record of 27:41.81, which he had set just a few months earlier at The Ten Championship in San Juan Capistrano in April this year.

"I was hoping to clock something around the 27:30 range. But when I saw that my average time for every kilometre was in the 2:43 range, I knew I had to push myself in the final few laps," he says.

While Gulveer's performance might have taken even him by surprise, it hasn't come as a shock to those who have been following his career. After first setting the national record in the 10,000m — incidentally, the then second-oldest record in Indian track history — he broke